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Day-of Timeline and Run of Show

Sample run-of-show schedules for a party, a wedding, and a corporate evening, plus load-in, emergency, and contact sheets.

A run of show is the minute-by-minute script that keeps your vendors, helpers, and guests moving in the same direction. Use the samples as a starting point, change the times to fit your event, and hand a copy to every vendor. The checklists and contact sheet make sure nobody is guessing on the big day.

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Chairs, tables, linens, tents and more across Chicagoland, on one quote.

PART 1

How to Use a Run of Show

- Work backward from the event start time and the venue curfew, then fill in the rest.
- Add 10 to 15 minute buffers around meals, speeches, and anything involving a crowd.
- List who is responsible for each item so no moment is left without an owner.
- Send the final version to every vendor at least two weeks before the event and again the day before.
- Print one copy for the host, one for the day-of coordinator, one for the DJ or emcee, and one for the caterer.
- Use the same clock for everyone. Agree on whose phone or watch is the official time.
- Build in a plan B for weather, late vendors, and running behind. Decide in advance what gets cut first.
- Tape a short version of the schedule where vendors can see it in the back of the house.

PART 2

Sample: 4-Hour Party Run of Show

Example for a 6:00 pm to 10:00 pm birthday, anniversary, or graduation party with a seated or buffet dinner. Adjust all times.

Time	What happens	Who is in charge
1:00 pm	Rental delivery: tables, chairs, linens, tent if needed	Host or helper receives and inspects
2:00 pm	Caterer and bartender arrive and set up	Caterer
3:00 pm	Decor, signage, and seating display go up	Host and helpers
4:30 pm	DJ or musician arrives, sound check	DJ
5:15 pm	Final walk-through and photo of the setup	Host
5:45 pm	Host and family ready, staff in position	Host
6:00 pm	Doors open, welcome drinks and appetizers	Bartender and servers
6:45 pm	Welcome toast or short speech	Host
7:00 pm	Dinner service begins	Caterer
7:45 pm	Dessert or cake cutting	Host and caterer
8:00 pm	Toasts, tributes, or slideshow	Emcee
8:30 pm	Dancing and activities begin	DJ
9:30 pm	Last call and cake to go	Bartender
9:50 pm	Send-off, thank guests, hand out favors	Host
10:00 pm	Music ends, begin breakdown	Everyone
11:00 pm	Rentals stacked or packed, trash out, venue cleared	Helpers and vendors

PART 3

Sample: Wedding Day Run of Show

Example for a 4:00 pm ceremony and an evening reception. Shift everything to match your actual start time.

Time	What happens	Who is in charge
8:00 am	Hair and makeup begin	Hair and makeup team
10:00 am	Florist delivers bouquets, boutonnieres, and arch pieces	Florist
11:00 am	Rental delivery: ceremony chairs, reception tables, linens, lighting	Planner or venue coordinator
12:00 pm	Light lunch for the wedding party	Maid of honor or best man
1:00 pm	Photographer arrives for getting-ready photos	Photographer
2:00 pm	DJ or band arrives and sets up	DJ
2:30 pm	Caterer starts setting up	Caterer
3:00 pm	Ceremony musicians arrive, final décor check	Planner
3:15 pm	Guests begin to arrive, ushers seat guests	Ushers
3:50 pm	Wedding party lines up	Planner
4:00 pm	Ceremony begins	Officiant
4:30 pm	Ceremony ends, family photos	Photographer
4:45 pm	Cocktail hour begins	Caterer and bartender
5:30 pm	Wedding party and couple photos continue	Photographer
6:00 pm	Grand entrance and first dance	DJ
6:20 pm	Welcome toast and dinner service	Best man, maid of honor, caterer
7:30 pm	Parent dances and cake cutting	DJ
8:00 pm	Open dancing	DJ
9:30 pm	Late-night snack, bouquet or garter moments if wanted	Caterer and DJ
10:30 pm	Last dance and send-off	DJ and photographer
11:00 pm	Gift collection, vendor breakdown	Planner and helpers
12:00 am	Venue empty, rentals ready for pickup	Venue and rental company

PART 4

Sample: Corporate Evening Event Run of Show

Example for a 5:30 pm to 9:30 pm awards dinner or client reception.

Time	What happens	Who is in charge
10:00 am	Rental delivery: tables, chairs, linens, stage, lighting	Event manager
12:00 pm	AV load-in and sound check	AV team
2:00 pm	Decor, signage, and registration table setup	Event staff
3:00 pm	Caterer arrives	Caterer
4:00 pm	Tech rehearsal with the presenter or emcee	Emcee and AV
4:45 pm	Staff briefing and name-tag review	Event manager
5:00 pm	Registration opens	Registration staff
5:30 pm	Reception and cocktail hour	Caterer and bartender
6:30 pm	Guests seated, welcome remarks	Emcee and CEO
6:45 pm	Dinner service	Caterer
7:30 pm	Awards or keynote program	Emcee
8:15 pm	Dessert and networking	Caterer
8:45 pm	Closing remarks and thank-yous	Emcee
9:00 pm	Guests depart, favors handed out	Event staff
9:30 pm	Load-out begins	AV and vendors
10:30 pm	Venue cleared, rentals counted and stacked	Event manager

PART 5

Vendor Arrival and Load-in Checklist

BEFORE VENDORS ARRIVE

- [ ] Confirm the venue load-in time, loading dock, and elevator rules in writing.
- [ ] Reserve parking or a loading zone for delivery trucks.
- [ ] Unlock doors, turn on lights, and set the thermostat before the first vendor arrives.
- [ ] Clear the space of existing furniture and storage items.
- [ ] Make sure restrooms and water access are available to vendors.
- [ ] Post a sign or send a map showing where each vendor should unload.

RENTAL DELIVERY

- [ ] Have a floor plan on site so the driver knows where each table and chair set goes.
- [ ] Count tables, chairs, linens, plates, glasses, and flatware against the order.
- [ ] Check for stains, tears, cracks, and missing items before signing.
- [ ] Take photos of any damage and note it on the delivery slip.
- [ ] Confirm the pickup time and where items should be stacked.
- [ ] Put tips for the delivery crew in a labeled envelope.

FOOD AND BEVERAGE

- [ ] Show the caterer the kitchen, power outlets, and sinks.
- [ ] Confirm where hot boxes, coolers, and ice will be stored.
- [ ] Give the bartender the bar location and the signature drink list.
- [ ] Make sure licensed alcohol service is in place and permits are visible.
- [ ] Plan a staff meal for caterers and vendors who work more than five hours.

ENTERTAINMENT, PHOTO, AND DECOR

- [ ] Give the DJ or band power access, a table, and a clear load-in path.
- [ ] Tell the photographer the schedule, must-have shots, and family groupings.
- [ ] Introduce the florist to the person who will approve placement.
- [ ] Confirm the officiant, emcee, or speakers know their cues.
- [ ] Keep a list of who has arrived, who is late, and who has left.

PART 6

Day-of Emergency Kit

Pack in a bin and hand it to your day-of coordinator.

REPAIRS AND TOOLS

- [ ] Scissors, tape, fishing line, and double-sided tape.
- [ ] Safety pins, sewing kit, and fabric glue.
- [ ] Zip ties, clips, and wire.
- [ ] Steamer or wrinkle spray for linens.
- [ ] Extension cords, power strip, and spare batteries.
- [ ] Flashlight and a headlamp for dark setup.

HEALTH AND COMFORT

- [ ] First aid kit, bandages, and pain relievers.
- [ ] Antacids, tissues, and allergy medicine.
- [ ] Sunscreen and bug spray.
- [ ] Umbrellas, ponchos, blankets, and hand warmers for cold Chicago nights.
- [ ] Water bottles, granola bars, and a cooler of cold drinks.
- [ ] Spare shoes, flip-flops, or blister bandages.

PAPER AND MONEY

- [ ] Master run of show and the contact sheet.
- [ ] Copies of vendor contracts and permits.
- [ ] Envelopes with tips and final payments.
- [ ] Cash for parking and small purchases.
- [ ] Pens, markers, and blank cards.
- [ ] Garbage bags, cleaning wipes, and paper towels.

PART 7

Day-of Contact Sheet

Fill this in, make four copies, and share with your coordinator, host, and key helpers.

HOST NAME AND CELL	DAY-OF COORDINATOR NAME AND CELL
VENUE CONTACT AND CELL	CATERER ON-SITE LEAD AND CELL
RENTAL COMPANY DISPATCH NUMBER	DJ OR BAND LEAD AND CELL
PHOTOGRAPHER AND CELL	VIDEOGRAPHER AND CELL
FLORIST AND CELL	OFFICIANT OR EMCEE AND CELL
BARTENDER AND CELL	TRANSPORTATION OR SHUTTLE AND CELL
NEAREST URGENT CARE OR HOSPITAL	BACKUP CONTACT AND RELATIONSHIP

PART 8

Questions to Ask Before the Day

1. What time can each vendor access the venue, and who unlocks the doors?
2. Where can vendors park, and do they need passes or permits?
3. Is there a freight elevator or only stairs?
4. What is the venue noise curfew, and when must the music end?
5. Who is authorized to approve changes on the day?
6. What is the weather backup plan, and who decides when to use it?
7. Who will collect gifts, cards, and personal items after the event?
8. What time must the venue be fully cleared and rentals ready for pickup?

NEXT STEP

Get every rental on one quote

Pick chairs, tables, linens, dinnerware, tents and decor from Chicago-area rental companies and see prices as you build your list at beyondchiavari.com/quote. Want a second set of eyes on your plan? Book a free planning call at beyondchiavari.com/book.

Planning rules of thumb only. Confirm counts, rules and timing with your venue and vendors. © Beyond Chiavari. Free to print and share for personal planning.